

CALIMESA FIRE DEPARTMENT
GUIDELINE MANUAL
VOLUME 6

Guideline: 608.04 Freeway Response

12/2023

Page 3 of 6

- a. Number of patients/extent of injuries
 - b. Extrication Needed
 - c. Evacuation
 - d. Hazardous Materials Spill
 - e. What's Burning, including any hazardous product
3. Call for Necessary Help
 - a. Stage additional assistance as needed

COMMAND POST LOCATION

The Command Post location should be carefully chosen for major incidents to provide access and a good view of the scene. The access frontage or an overpass provides a view of the scene for incidents on depressed roadway sections.

UNIFIED COMMAND

It's important to establish a single "Unified Command" Post as soon as possible. Key agencies at this Command Post will be the fire department, the California Highway Patrol, the California Department of Transportation (Caltrans) and if freeway traffic is being diverted to city streets, the appropriate city police will need to be party to the Command Post operation.

It's important to physically assemble all representatives at a single location as soon as possible. This may require the initial fire department commander to search out the CHP and Caltrans representatives. Once a physical location for the Command Post is determined, all agencies should advise their dispatchers of that location.

Dispatch centers must be advised of any changes in the Command Post.

When the fire department is first to arrive the Incident Commander must announce the command vehicles identity (i.e. Engine 21) and the vehicle's location (i.e. 50 feet east of the accident). Dispatch will relay the location to CHP. Dispatch must be advised of any change of Command Post locations.

LIAISON WITH CHP

CALIMESA FIRE DEPARTMENT
GUIDELINE MANUAL
VOLUME 6

Guideline: 608.04 Freeway Response

12/2023

Page 4 of 6

In some occasions, particularly early in the incident, it may be more appropriate for a fire department representative to serve as a liaison officer to the CHP Incident Commander. This liaison should be a temporary function and should end when all agency representatives assemble Command Staff at a unified Command Post.

When the need to shut down freeway traffic is indicated Command must make a joint assessment of conditions with the CHP and police department. The logistical and traffic congestion problems created by a complete shutdown of freeway traffic may last for hours and affect a large area of the city. A decision to close the freeway must recognize these factors in relation to the safety of the incident.

SPECIAL CONSIDERATIONS

Each company officer is responsible to research or know the location of hydrants and access to the freeway. Water supplies and other factors must be pre-planned by the first due officers. Some typical factors which must be considered:

EXAMPLES:

1. Early call for additional companies to handle lines that may have to be extended long distances over obstacles.
2. Relay pumping probabilities.
3. Special equipment needs (tenders, foam, sand, diking materials, wreckers, etc.).
4. Early call for traffic control.
5. Sewers, drains, and pump stations (when dealing with spilled products).
6. Peak traffic hours create congestion and delays.
7. Access to the freeway (ladders, on/off ramps, etc.).
8. Hazardous Materials Team.

APPARATUS PLACEMENT

Whenever possible, place apparatus between oncoming traffic and operating personnel in order to protect the scene from approaching vehicles. Warning lights must be visible to oncoming traffic. Avoiding unnecessary blocking of traffic lanes will permit CHP to move traffic and relieve congestion.

CALIMESA FIRE DEPARTMENT
GUIDELINE MANUAL
VOLUME 6

Guideline: 608.04 Freeway Response

12/2023

Page 5 of 6

Employ rear lights, flares, reflectors, or cones as required or as directed by the CHP Traffic control. Warning devices should be left to the CHP whenever possible. Communicate with the CHP whenever flammable liquid leaks, spills, etc., are present regarding using flares.

Leave one crewmember to watch the traffic and set up warning devices until the CHP arrives. Parking brakes are to be set, and the apparatus set with the wheels at an angle to the side.

1. Consider parking above or below (on access frontage) if the traffic conditions are such that entry is impossible or difficult.
2. A booster line or other hose line may be employed as a rope to ascend or descend to the freeway proper.
3. Where the freeway is elevated, a ladder is an effective means to gain access and to effect evacuation from above
4. Only the apparatus that is absolutely necessary shall be taken onto the freeway, under the direction of Command. The first due unit will proceed into the scene. All other units will stage off the freeway, if possible, to await an assignment.
5. Position apparatus in a safe manner to protect the scene from traffic. Keep CHP aware that you are blocking a lane of traffic.
6. Do your job as rapidly as possible and then clear the traffic lanes.
7. In sections of depressed roadway, it is faster to have a company above "drop" a line than one advanced up the slope.
8. Several sections of the freeway have no access frontages and will require laying hose for long distances from on-ramps if a supply line is needed. Relay pumping and tenders should be considered in these cases.

Term	Definition	Other Names
"Access Road"	Road parallel to freeway	"Frontage Road"
"Against the Wall"	Area around the median barrier wall	"Inside Shoulder" "Median Wall"
"Distress Lane"	Usually refers to the area between the median barrier wall and the number one traffic lane; may also refer to the emergency lane	"Emergency Lane"
"Gore Point"	Area around freeway entrance and exit	"Gore"
"H.O.V. Lane"	High Occupancy Vehicle lane	"Car Pool Lane", "Bus

CALIMESA FIRE DEPARTMENT
GUIDELINE MANUAL
VOLUME 6

Guideline: 608.04 Freeway Response

12/2023

Page 6 of 6

"Main lane"	Controlled access freeway	Lane", or "Diamond Lane"
"Shoulder"	Usually refers to the area off the roadway to the right of the emergency lane; may also refer to the median area near the left side of the roadway	
"Unified Command"	Command post consisting of more than one agency	

Lane numbering sequence: No. 1 is the traffic lane nearest the median or center, excluding the H.O.V. lane.

CALIMESA FIRE DEPARTMENT

GUIDELINE MANUAL

VOLUME 6

Guideline: 608.05 Tire Fires

12/2023

Page 1 of 7

Tire fires present the same potential threat to the environment that an incident involving an oil tanker or a railroad tank car carrying hazardous substances.

The average passenger car tire holds 2.5 gallons of oil. When exposed to extreme heat the tires reach a state of combustion where volumes of pyrolytic oil can be produced. This could turn the tire pile into a running oil fire. Exposure hazards associated with the smoke plume, water runoff and soil include:

1. Volatile organic chemicals
2. Polynuclear aromatic hydrocarbons
3. Carbon monoxide
4. Heavy metals

These toxins can be absorbed either through the skin, mucus membranes or respiratory system.

The success of any fire suppression operation begins at the company level. The company officer should familiarize his/her crew with all scrap tire piles located within their area of response. Information gathered should be entered in the pre-plan record for the specific locations.

Areas of consideration should include:

1. Site Location
2. Type of Operation
 - a. Salvage or Recycling
 - b. Managed or Unmanaged
3. Tire Piles Composition
 - a. Whole
 - b. Burned
 - c. Shredded
 - d. Random stack
4. Tire Pile Size
5. Available Equipment
6. Hazards
7. Exposures
8. Utilities
 - a. Overhead Wires
 - b. Underground Gas, Electrical or Communication
9. Response Conditions
10. Geographical Information
11. Topography
12. Emergency Contacts

CALIMESA FIRE DEPARTMENT

GUIDELINE MANUAL

VOLUME 6

Guideline: 608.05 Tire Fires

12/2023

Page 2 of 7

DEPLOYMENT SERVICES

It is recommended that major tire fires be handled as hazardous materials incidents. The Dispatch Center will obtain all available information from the caller to determine what's on fire. A hazardous materials team will be dispatched if it is determined that a tire pile is on fire.

SIZE-UP

Upon arrival the company officer must determine the stage of combustion the tire pile is in.

1. Incipient
2. Free burning
3. Smoldering

The incipient stage of a tire fire begins with a point of ignition. Once a tire has gained an open flame front, the surrounding tire material absorbs the heat of the fire. Immediately separating the burning tire from the rest of the pile and/or applying water and foam would eliminate the threat to the remaining tires.

During the free burning stage fire spreads quickly and there is a dramatic increase in smoke and heat. Use of water in this stage of a tire fire could increase the products of incomplete combustion like carbon monoxide and particulate matter. The cooled tires may continue to pyrolyze, producing large quantities of oil. A crust may form over the pile while internal temperatures reach about 2,000° Fahrenheit. The smoldering stage has begun.

Oil not consumed by the fire will leach into the soil, pool and begin to flow under the pile. Heat from the fire could ignite the oil resulting in a three-dimensional fire. Products of incomplete combustion continue to be a health hazard.

During the initial size-up the company officer must determine if the fire can be extinguished quickly without endangering personnel. If the fire is in the free burning or smoldering stage the most immediate concern will be the life safety of fire fighters and the community. Approach to the incident should be in accordance with tactics common to other potential hazardous materials incidents.

CALIMESA FIRE DEPARTMENT

GUIDELINE MANUAL

VOLUME 6

Guideline: 608.05 Tire Fires

12/2023

Page 3 of 7

Initial size-up must evaluate the emergency in terms of:

1. Personnel safety
2. Public health
3. Environmental impact
4. Threatened exposures
5. Extent of fire
6. Need for additional resources

Personnel Safety Awareness of the hazards involved in a tire fire can be the best personnel protection. Heat exhaustion and working in less than ideal conditions is a reality in a large tire fire. Command will want to prepare for total exposures, health hazards and personal injury hazards.

Full turnout gear is the minimum level of protection required for everyone working the tire fire.

1. Boots
2. Turnout pants
3. Turnout coat
4. Gloves
5. Helmet
6. Nomex hood
7. S.C.B.A.

NOTE: Surgical gloves under the leather gloves will give added protection from contact with the contaminated water, oil and mud.

The risk of exposure to toxic chemicals continues after the fire is out. Smoldering tires are as toxic as tires in a free burning state. Flying ash and contaminated soil are also potential hazards. The temptation to dress down for overhaul should be resisted until the hazardous materials team has determined the appropriate level of protective clothing required.

Command will establish personnel accountability. When multiple points of entry to the incident exist geographic sectors should be established i.e., lobby north, lobby east, etc.

The Incident Commander will establish a decontamination zone for all personnel leaving the fire

CALIMESA FIRE DEPARTMENT

GUIDELINE MANUAL

VOLUME 6

Guideline: 608.05 Tire Fires

12/2023

Page 4 of 7

area. All protective clothing, firefighting equipment, and apparatus will need to be decontaminated as well.

Personnel must be aware of other hazards involving scrap tire fires. Contact with rodents, mosquitoes, snakes, spiders, and scorpions will be reduced with protective clothing.

Be aware of the dangers of machinery and heavy equipment operating on the fire scene. Collapsing walls of tires can block escape routes or cut off water supplies.

PUBLIC HEALTH

Command should determine early whether to evacuate the surrounding areas. No strategy for managing the incident should bypass evacuation considerations since burning tires are extremely difficult to extinguish.

ENVIRONMENTAL IMPACT

Command should size-up the potential environmental consequences of the fire and begin notifying the appropriate agencies. Early notification will facilitate their timely placement into the Command structure and involvement in the incident.

Areas of concern will include:

1. Life Safety
2. Proximity of Wildlands
3. Potential Toxic Run-Off
4. Bodies of Water
5. Smoke Plume
6. Wind Direction/Speed

TACTICS

Important tactical considerations include:

1. Life Safety
2. Protecting Exposures
3. Isolating Burning Tires
4. Use of Heavy Equipment
5. Overhead or Underground Utilities

Immediate evacuation of the incident scene is a high priority. Every effort should address life